

Course Website: <https://q.utoronto.ca/courses/445736>

Course Email: eco101.freitas@utoronto.ca. See section 1.4.

Adjust your Quercus [notification settings](#) so you don't miss important information.

1 Course Overview

You have an unscheduled hour on a Saturday morning. Rare “free” time, right? Not quite. You could binge-watch something, sleep, visit a friend, or study. Picking one means giving up the chance to do the next best thing. Your “free” time has an *opportunity cost*, a central concept in economics.

ECO101 introduces you to a few general principles economists use to think through choices people and firms make. We examine the patterns those choices produce in markets, and how markets respond when conditions change. For example: what happens to laptop prices when data centres expand rapidly? Who effectively pays a new \$1 gas tax—drivers or gas stations? Does a higher minimum wage lead to job losses?

We answer questions like these by starting from assumptions that make a complicated reality manageable, so we can focus on the mechanisms that matter. Knowing which assumptions your predictions rest on is what lets you adapt your reasoning to new situations and recognize the limitations of your analysis.

That skill only comes from doing it. You'll learn how to problem-solve using economic principles by working through questions on your own, and with your classmates in workshops and tutorials. In short, lots of practice! When opportunity cost thinking becomes second nature, you're on your way to becoming an economist.

1.1 Learning Objectives

By the end of the course, you should be able to:

- Set up and solve choice problems for individuals and firms, adapting them to specific questions and contexts.
- Explain how individuals and firms interacting in a market determine what gets produced, who gets it, and at what price, and evaluate whether the outcome is efficient.
- Given a scenario you haven't seen before, identify and use the appropriate ECO101 concepts to reach an answer.
- Present your reasoning using math, graphs, and clear English, and move between them.
- Critically analyze economic arguments using course concepts, explaining where and why the logic holds or breaks down.

1.2 Course Information

Meeting times and location:

Section	Workshop	Location	Tutorial
L301	Tuesdays, 1-3 PM	OI G162	Register for one tutorial from the options available for your section on ACORN .
L401	Tuesdays, 3-5 PM	OI G162	
L501	Wednesdays, 1-3 PM	OI G162	

Workshops: You'll solve problems with your classmates, explain your reasoning, and learn from mistakes. Completing the week's readings and videos before the workshop gives you the background knowledge to make your time productive.

Tutorials: This is your chance to work through posted questions in smaller groups with a TA. To get the most out of your time, attempt them beforehand and take your reasoning to tutorial.

Office hours: Stop by to talk to me and the course TAs throughout the week, at times posted on Quercus. You don't need "good" questions or even to have questions. You can learn from your classmates' questions, use the space to work with them, or just say hello.

The [Economics Study Center](#) in [GE](#) room 110 is staffed by undergraduate students who have taken our courses and done well in them.

Much of what you learn you'll learn from each other, and discussions are better when perspectives differ. That only works if people feel comfortable speaking, so be kind, and assume anyone asking a question or contributing to a discussion has good reasons and intentions. Everyone is welcome in this course.

Grading scheme: All graded work is individual work unless explicitly specified otherwise (see section [2.1](#)). We do not offer extra credit assignments. Participation work is deliberately low-stakes and designed to prepare you for assessments requiring independent problem-solving and reward consistent effort.

Test	Weight	Due Date
Entry Quiz	1%	Tuesday 22-Sept, 5:00 PM on Quercus
Midterm 1	25%	Friday, 16-Oct, 6-8 PM
Midterm 2	25%	Friday, 20-Nov, 6-8 PM
Final Exam	40%	December Final Exam period, 3 hrs, date and time TBD by A&S
Workshop Participation	4.5%	Completed during in-person workshops
Weekly Participation Quizzes	4.5%	Online on Quercus, due dates listed on each quiz

1.3 Required Materials

Required Text: Krugman, Wells, Au, and Parkinson, *Microeconomics, Fifth Canadian Edition*, 2025. More details on Quercus. We are not using Achieve for graded coursework.

Course Videos: For each topic, I post videos. I will assume you have watched them before workshops.

Prep Coach (optinal): This year we're piloting an AI tutor to help you prepare for workshops. See section [5.4](#) and Quercus.

1.4 Communication

This is a very large course, and while we would like to correspond with each of you individually, that can get out of hand quickly. To help us make this process efficient, please follow the guidelines below. This will allow us to answer all your questions and also have time to improve the course.

- **In person:** If you have a quick question, try asking us in person during office hours, before or after workshops/tutorials. Personal connections in a large class make us all feel better.
- **Piazza:** This is an online discussion board meant to facilitate *student-to-student* interaction so everyone can benefit from the answers. It is *not* an online helpdesk to reach course staff.
- **Course email:** Use eco101.freitas@utoronto.ca for questions about your **individual situation**.

We redirect questions about course content to the discussion board and office hours, where everyone can benefit from the answer.

For privacy and identification purposes, we can only respond to messages sent from your U of T email. Do not use Quercus inbox.

If we can answer your email briefly, we will try to respond within 3 business days. If you do not get a reply, please check Quercus, the syllabus, or drop by office hours.

- **Prof. Freitas:** k.freitas@utoronto.ca. Use for course problems that need immediate attention like a broken link.

2 Graded Work

2.1 Academic Integrity

Every piece of graded work in this course measures how far along you are at reaching the learning objectives in section 1.1. It only means something if it is yours and completed unaided. Work completed with help from a tutor, a website, a classmate, or a generative AI tool does not capture your achievement.

- Unless told otherwise, **any work submitted for grades must be completed on your own without assistance**. No discussing any part of it, no looking up answers, no soliciting or receiving help from tutors or classmates. Workshop participation is an exception because collaboration with classmates during workshops is expected. **No generative AI tools or assistance for graded work**.
- **Participation work is graded work**. It's designed to give you chances to test your knowledge and fix gaps before they show up on tests. Don't waste those chances by taking shortcuts.

Why this matters for you

- **Economics is sequenced**. The courses after this one are built on what you're learning in this one, and they don't re-teach it. Shortcuts now compound gaps quietly, and closing them later takes far more work than learning things properly the first time.
- **In a world with AI, your ability to do the higher-order thinking is especially valuable**. You cannot build it without a strong foundation. If you have ever struggled with harder math, denser readings, or more complicated writing because you never quite nailed the basics, you already know what I mean.

What this does not prohibit: help while studying. Use whatever helps you learn, including classmates, office hours, Piazza, the textbook. Yes, AI too (see section 5.4), but with a word of advice. Learning is supposed to feel hard and take time. The friction helps our brains make sense of what we're learning. Things that make learning too easy give us a false sense of proficiency, which we only discover when we perform tasks unaided.

You may hit a week where you're behind, stressed, and out of time, and a shortcut starts to look reasonable. Check section 4 for options on where to get help instead.

We report all suspected cases to the Department of Economics and SAI, and the consequences can be severe. Read the University of Toronto's [Code of Behaviour on Academic Matters](#).

2.2 How to do well in ECO101

Before we get to details on graded work, let me address the biggest source of anxiety for students in this course. You already know the answer to succeeding in this course. Think of anything outside of academics you're good at. How did you get good at it? The answer is usually regular deliberate practice, learning from mistakes and time management.

In my experience, when effort doesn't show up in your grades it is typically because your study strategies need adjustment. What worked in high school often does not transfer to university. Quercus has more resources and advice to help you with this. Learning strategists in the Academic Success Centre or in Rotman Commerce, can help. It is worth a single appointment early rather than a post-midterm crisis.

2.3 Midterm Tests and Final Exam

All tests are **in-person** with the exact date, time, and location announced on Quercus. Coverage and format details will be posted closer to the date.

The final exam is cumulative (i.e. covers all course content). Each student in ECO101 this semester will answer the same set of questions in the final exam, covering core material common to all sections and instructors. There may be instructor-specific questions as well.

Midterm regrade requests are accepted via a MS Form on Quercus. It will open one week after the test is returned and closes a week after that. Requests are accepted only during that period and are batch processed after the deadline. We will re-read your entire assessment so your mark could go up, down, or remain unchanged.

2.4 Participation Grades

We have two opportunities every week to earn participation grades:

Workshops: Complete worksheets on paper and hand them in at the end of the workshop. If constraints arise and you need to attend a different workshop for a particular week, you can. The first workshop you attend for that week will count. Submissions will be graded for effort and completeness.

Participation quizzes: Completed on Quercus, each available for about one week. Only attempts completed during this window count for grades. This is your low-cost way to test your knowledge and fix gaps before the test.

- Multiple retakes are allowed, and the highest score counts. You're not allowed to get help, discuss or collaborate when completing the quiz.

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- After the deadline, the quiz will be available as a practice quiz. Practice quiz grades do not count for participation grades.
 - Score calculation: If your highest score is 70% or higher, it is rounded up to 100% at the end of the course. For scores below 70%, there is no rounding. Not happy with your score? Retake it before the deadline.

We drop your lowest 3 of 12 scores in each category. This is automatic, for every student, and you do not need to email us or give a reason. It is there to cover illness, a bad week, a religious or extracurricular conflict, a technology failure, or an accidental submission.

2.5 Entry Quiz

The entry quiz is meant to help flag some things you should pay attention to and let us learn something about you. The grade gives you an incentive to complete it before the deadline. No course content knowledge required. Answering all questions gives you full points.

3 Accommodations

If you have an acute or ongoing disability issue or accommodation need, you should register with [Accessibility Services \(AS\)](#) at the beginning of the academic year. For testing accommodations (e.g. extra time on a timed test) you must register with [Accommodated Testing Services \(ATS\)](#). AS will assess your situation, develop an accommodation plan with you, and support you in requesting accommodation for your course work. As every student is different and has different needs, we rely on their expertise to determine what accommodations are best for you.

We will also try to arrange for reasonable accommodation of the needs of students who observe religious holy days other than those already accommodated by ordinary scheduling and statutory holidays. Please contact us as soon as possible.

4 Getting Help

While it may feel like you're the only one struggling, it is not true. Trust me. Instead of trying to figure things out alone, reach out right away. Don't wait until things get to a crisis point.

Difficulties with Course Concepts

Sometimes being able to talk through conceptual difficulties with a person helps. Stop by our office hours or the [Economics Study Center](#).

Study groups: Form one by connecting with classmates in workshops, tutorials, or office hours. If you want something more structured, look at the [Recognized Study Group](#) program at UofT.

Try posting your question on Piazza and answering questions posted by your classmates. Explaining something is one of the best ways to find out whether you actually understand it.

Longer-term Issues that Affect Multiple Courses

- **Mental Health:** University is difficult and sometimes we all need a little help. Two good places to start are the [Telus Health Student Support](#) app (linked in Quercus on the left-hand tab) and [your registrar](#).

If you're in distress, you can access immediate support: <https://uoft.me/feelingdistressed>

As a UofT student, you can access free mental health and wellbeing services at [Health & Wellness](#) such as same day counselling, brief counselling, medical care, skill-building workshops, and drop-in peer support. You can also meet with a Wellness Navigation Advisor who can connect you with other campus and community services and support. Visit <https://uoft.me/mentalhealthcare> to learn about the services available to you.

- **Your registrar:** When an issue requires academic consideration, they can help you figure out options and associated documentation. They can also advise you on course selections, university regulations, and connect you with university resources. They are important partners in ECO101, and we rely on their expertise.
- For longer-term acute illnesses that require test accommodations (e.g. concussions or a broken hand) you should contact [Accessibility Services \(AS\)](#) and [Accommodated Testing Services \(ATS\)](#) as soon as possible.

5 Course Policies

5.1 Missed work

Every student at UofT has a College or Faculty Registrar. They are the people who handle academic consideration when something serious happens, and their help is free. If you do not know which one is yours, [find out now](#), before you need them.

For any ongoing injury, illness, or personal/family problems that last longer than 5 days, you must contact your College Registrar immediately.

5.1.1 Missed Participation Work

We drop your lowest 3 of 12 scores in each category. This is automatic, for every student, and you do not need to email us or give a reason. It is there to cover illness, a bad week, a religious or extracurricular conflict, a technology failure, or an accidental submission.

The drop policy is the only accommodation for missed weekly work. We do not accept late submissions or grant extensions on weekly work, for any reason. This is regular work spread across the term, and an extension only pushes the load into a week when you are already behind.

Any exception requires your College Registrar to advocate on your behalf. If you are going to miss more than the drops cover, talk to your registrar. Take documentation for *all* missed work, including the automatic drops to your meeting. An option to discuss with them is taking the course in a term when you can give it the attention it needs.

5.1.2 Missed Tests

Midterm: To request a make-up midterm you need to

- (1) Submit a make-up request via MS Forms on Quercus AND
- (2) Provide documentation. There are three options for documentation:

A: Complete an Absence Declaration on ACORN.

Put the course email when asked for the instructor's email: eco101.freitas@utoronto.ca.

Upload a copy/screenshot of your absence declaration that includes your name on the MS Form.

See: <https://help.acorn.utoronto.ca/blog/uFAQs/how-do-i-declare-an-absence/>.

B: If you have used your Absence Declaration for the semester, you must have a medical doctor complete a [UofT Verification of Illness Form](#) indicating a moderate, serious, or severe illness.

Guidelines and form FAQ here: <https://www.registrar.utoronto.ca/records-academics/verification-of-illness-or-injury/>. Upload a copy onto the MS Form at submission time.

Within a week of the test, you will need to submit the original form to the economics reception in [GE \(Max Gluskin\)](#). If you do not submit the original, your make-up will not be approved.

C: College registrar's letter or a Letter of Academic Accommodation from Accessibility Services. Take this syllabus when meeting with them to request your letter.

- There is one **cumulative** (i.e. covers midterm 1 and midterm 2 content) make-up test. It will be held in the **last week of classes**, typically **late evening (e.g. 8:00 PM)** to minimize conflicts with other courses. You will usually get the date, time, and location information **via email 2-3 days before the test**, so please check your email regularly around that time. We need to wait for students to complete the form, verify documentation, and make arrangements.
- The make-up score substitutes for only one missed midterm.
- There is no make-up test for a missed make-up test. If you miss the make-up, or miss two midterms, please meet your college registrar as soon as possible. Take this syllabus and documentation for *all* missed work. Your registrar can help you assess your options, including whether continuing in the course is feasible.
- You will get your grades for the make-up after the drop deadline. Deadlines for CR/NCR or LWDs are here: <https://www.artsci.utoronto.ca/current/dates-deadlines/academic-dates>
- The format may differ from the class test. Study strategies should be the same as the regular class midterms.

The university policy on student absences: <https://www.artsci.utoronto.ca/current/academics/student-absences>

Final: The Faculty of Arts & Science (A&S) [deals with missed final exams](#).

See <https://www.artsci.utoronto.ca/current/faculty-registrar/petitions/deferred-exams>

5.2 Crowdmark

This course will use Crowdmark, a collaborative online grading tool for marking and providing feedback on graded term assessments. Crowdmark provides efficiencies with grading, data recording, returning term assessments and handling regrade requests. Copies of student work marked in Crowdmark, including grading and feedback, will be available online to students for at least one year. Digital (i.e., online) copies will serve as the authoritative record for course administrative purposes, and paper copies of assessments scanned and uploaded to Crowdmark will be destroyed after the term has ended and final grades are approved. If you have questions about how your information is stored on Crowdmark, please contact your course instructor.

5.3 Policy on Course Materials and Recordings

Some elements of this course, including your participation, may be recorded on video and will be available to students. For questions about recording and use of videos in which you appear, please contact me.

Course materials, including content videos, belong to your instructor, the University, and/or other sources depending on the specific facts of each situation, and are protected by copyright. Do not download, copy, or share any course or student materials without the explicit permission of the instructor. **Students should not create their own recordings of any course events (e.g. workshops, tutorials, and office hours).** If you require an accommodation for a disability, please speak to me first. Students creating unauthorized audio recordings of in-person sessions or activities may be subject to disciplinary actions under the Code of Student Conduct.

5.4 Cogniti

This course will be using Cogniti - a University of Toronto generative AI chatbot tool, similar to ChatGPT or Microsoft Copilot, but specifically tailored to course content and integrated within Quercus. It is entirely optional and does not replace any course supports. Like all AI, it may occasionally provide inaccurate responses, so please always refer to our official course materials, the instructor, and TAs as authoritative sources.

Detailed terms of use available here: <https://teaching.utoronto.ca/teaching-uoft-genai/genai-tools/cogniti-terms-of-use/>

More details on how and why we will use it on Quercus.

5.5 Final Grades in ECO 101

The numerical grades in this course have and will correspond to [A&S interpretation of scores](#). Historically, the median mark has been in the C+ range. With multiple sections and different exams, the averages may vary across tests and sections. For example, your section could have a low average on a midterm. Don't worry! We have a common portion in the final for all in-person sections. We will use the performance on this common portion to adjust the final grades across sections to reflect this, if needed.

6 List of Topics

Week	Module(s)	Textbook Chapter(s)
1	Thinking like an Economist	1 & 9.1-9.4
2	Gains from Trade	2, 2 appendix & 8.1
3	Supply, Demand & Competitive Markets	3 & appendix
4	Elasticity	6 & 6 appendix
5	Surplus	4
6	Market Interventions	5 & 7
7	Firm Costs	11
8	Perfect Competition	12
9	Monopoly and Price Discrimination	13.1-13.6
10	Labour Markets	19
11	Game Theory and Oligopoly	14
12	Externalities	16